

5-31-2025

A Teacher, a Tutor, a Friend: ChatGPT and the High School Experience

Saisha Gupta

Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA, saisha.gupta@gmail.com

Vivek Mehta

Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA, vivek07mehta@gmail.com

Rebecca Kam

Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA, kitzel.kam@gmail.com

Caroline Ehmann

Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA, caehmann@gmail.com

Alma Orgad

Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA, alma.orgad@gmail.com

For more and additional works at: <https://nsuworks.nova.edu/tqr>



Part of the Communication Technology and New Media Commons, Community-Based Research Commons, Digital Humanities Commons, Educational Sociology Commons, English Language and Literature Commons, Place and Environment Commons, Quantitative, Qualitative, Comparative, and Historical Methodologies Commons, Secondary Education Commons, and the Social Psychology Commons

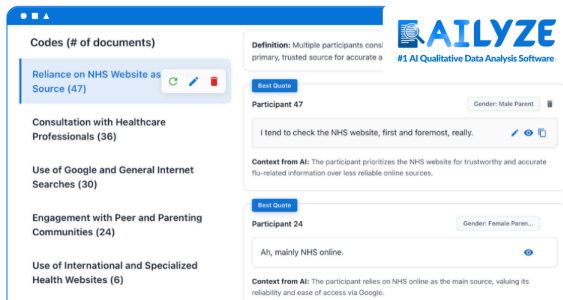
Recommended Citation

Gupta, S., Mehta, V., Kam, R., Ehmann, C., Orgad, A., Kuang, E., Castro Barrantes, A., Posada, M., Shah, S., Prasad, N., Pai, T., Ho, E., Xi, S., Zhou, T., Li, E., Wan, S., Paranjape, S., Dearling, Z., Peng, S. (G.), Kaveti, A., Lowrance, G., Xie, A. Z., Xu, M., Hariram, A., & Muse, A. (2025). A teacher, a tutor, a friend: ChatGPT and the high school experience. *The Qualitative Report*, 30(5), 3686-3719. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2025.7324>

This Article is brought to you for free and open access by the The Qualitative Report at NSUWorks. It has been accepted for inclusion in The Qualitative Report by an authorized administrator of NSUWorks. For more information, please contact nsuworks@nova.edu.

>90% AI Coding Accuracy

[Read study](#) [Free \(First 200\)](#)



A Teacher, a Tutor, a Friend: ChatGPT and the High School Experience

Abstract

Given the increasing emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) in education, high school students' perspectives on ChatGPT are underrepresented in current research literature. As high school student researchers in an English Language Arts course, we approached this gap in literature by asking the question: In what ways do pressures within high school communities influence students' perspectives on justifying or rejecting the use of ChatGPT? We interviewed 24 secondary students and conducted a thematic and discourse analysis, coding the interviews through the lenses of social goods (Gee, 2014), Figured Worlds (Holland et al., 1998), and positioning theory (Holland et al., 1998; Ingram & Elliott, 2019). We found that participants did not interpret ChatGPT within a binary accept-or-reject vacuum; rather, the ways in which students perceived the intersection of ChatGPT, social goods, and pressures informed the extent to which they positioned ChatGPT as a benefit or a detriment. Moreover, these social goods within the Figured World of school—e.g., high grades, learning, efficiency, ethics, humanity, and superiority—were determined and strengthened by pressures derived from other Worlds—e.g., parents, peers, and teachers. Lastly, we propose a set of general recommendations for policymaking at the teacher and administrative levels.

Keywords

ChatGPT, high school, secondary education, pressure, student perspective, generative AI, Figured Worlds, social goods, identity

Creative Commons License



This work is licensed under a [Creative Commons Attribution-Noncommercial-Share Alike 4.0 International License](#).

Acknowledgements

From Lexington Public Schools (Massachusetts), we want to thank Ms. Jane Day, English Department Chair, Mr. Scott Kmack, dean, Mr. Andrew Baker, principal, and especially Dr. Julie Hackett, superintendent. Each of them went above and beyond to support this project, writing letters of approval, and providing opportunities to present our research. Additionally, we would like to acknowledge Dr. Velda Elliott from the University of Oxford for providing guidance, advice, and the opportunity to present at the university. We would like to thank Dr. Sally St. George and Dr. Dan Wulff for working with us so patiently, walking us through this process chunk by chunk. Finally, we want to acknowledge our peers who began this project in Spring 2023 in Literature and Composition II: Nour Aboshady, Sophia Alcacaer, Laya Barghuthi, Calliope Bruce, Geneva Carter, Philip Chung, Anna Fullerton, Micaela Gebrael, Taili Gao, Kabir

Gokarn, Vaidehi Gupta, Calix Huang, Sofia Kalofonos, Ellie Kim, Alkisti Kokkinia, Lucy Kontos, Anna Labbe, Arthur Lin, Charlotte Longley, Abigail Man, Susannah McElheny, Kaavya Moogala, Juliana Nudi, Tyler Portillo, Bella Qu, Sofia Rosica, Mirei Saneyoshi, Sophie Shaw, Sophie Schenk, Catherine Taibi, Sophia Tang, Athina-Anna Vlachos, Angela Yates, Guhan Yuvaraj, and Emily Zhou.

Authors

Saisha Gupta, Vivek Mehta, Rebecca Kam, Caroline Ehmann, Alma Orgad, Emily Kuang, Alejandro Castro Barrantes, Matthew Posada, Samay Shah, Nikhita Prasad, Tara Pai, Eileen Ho, Shirley Xi, Tianyi Zhou, Elaina Li, Stephanie Wan, Shreya Paranjape, Zoe Dearling, Siqi (Grace) Peng, Aanya Kaveti, Gwendolyn Lowrance, Angela Ziyi Xie, Mira Xu, Adhiti Hariram, and Alexa Muse

A Teacher, a Tutor, a Friend: ChatGPT and the High School Experience

Saisha Gupta¹, Vivek Mehta¹, Rebecca Kam¹, Caroline Ehmann¹, Alma Orgad¹, Emily Kuang¹, Alejandro Castro Barrantes¹, Matthew Posada¹, Samay Shah¹, Nikhita Prasad¹, Tara Pai¹, Eileen Ho¹, Shirley Xi¹, Tianyi Zhou¹, Elaina Li¹, Stephanie Wan¹, Shreya Paranjape¹, Zoe Dearling¹, Siqi (Grace) Peng¹, Anya Kaveti¹, Gwendolyn Lowrance¹, Angela Ziyi Xie¹, Mira Xu¹, Adhiti Hariram¹, and Alexa Muse^{2,*}

¹Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA

²University of Oxford, United Kingdom and Lexington High School, Massachusetts, USA

Given the increasing emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) in education, high school students' perspectives on ChatGPT are underrepresented in current research literature. As high school student researchers in an English Language Arts course, we approached this gap in literature by asking the question: In what ways do pressures within high school communities influence students' perspectives on justifying or rejecting the use of ChatGPT? We interviewed 24 secondary students and conducted a thematic and discourse analysis, coding the interviews through the lenses of social goods (Gee, 2014), Figured Worlds (Holland et al., 1998), and positioning theory (Holland et al., 1998; Ingram & Elliott, 2019). We found that participants did not interpret ChatGPT within a binary accept-or-reject vacuum; rather, the ways in which students perceived the intersection of ChatGPT, social goods, and pressures informed the extent to which they positioned ChatGPT as a benefit or a detriment. Moreover, these social goods within the Figured World of school—e.g., high grades, learning, efficiency, ethics, humanity, and superiority—were determined and strengthened by pressures derived from other Worlds—e.g., parents, peers, and teachers. Lastly, we propose a set of general recommendations for policymaking at the teacher and administrative levels.

Keywords: ChatGPT, high school, secondary education, pressure, student perspective, generative AI, Figured Worlds, social goods, identity

Introduction

Open the heavy doors of many high schools, and the weight of students' stress is palpable. They shuffle in, shoulders heavy, not only from backpacks, but from the looming pressure of deadlines. Open a laptop, and the blue-light glow of the screen reflects tired eyes. "No AI," the syllabus now declares. One teacher proclaims, "Essays found using ChatGPT will earn an automatic zero." In another classroom, students open their pencil cases because teachers won't be taking any chances. Yet, their hand cramps are minute in comparison to the relentless pressure of perfection. In the hallways, fragments of conversations proliferate: "I'm drowning in work!" "How can I finish all this?" "I heard they were accused of using AI." Whispers like these result from the mounting stress that students face each day. In this stress-

* Co-head researchers: Saisha Gupta, Vivek Mehta, and Rebecca Kam

filled environment, where balancing high school life—from academic to the personal—is a constant challenge, tools such as ChatGPT have sparked an ongoing debate about the ethical boundaries of artificial intelligence in education. As high schoolers in this specific context, we began our research project with the question: In what ways do pressures within high school communities influence students' perspectives on justifying or rejecting the use of ChatGPT?

ChatGPT was developed by OpenAI and made available to the public in 2022. Recently, although our research focuses on secondary school, it has grown in popularity among students at all levels of education, as well as the global mainstream population (Mearian, 2023). ChatGPT's rapid generative ability has sparked debates within academic institutions regarding its effects on student thinking, learning skills, and academic integrity (Wong, 2023). By synthesising sources from the internet, ChatGPT can convincingly write laborious essays in seconds that would take humans hours (Zhang & Aslan, 2021).

Post ChatGPT's release, educators raised questions about the use of generative AI programs in post-secondary education and its impact on student academic integrity (Cu & Hochman, 2023). Moreover, several responses to generative AI use in schools were formed: higher education institutions either outright banned ChatGPT; created policies to limit use without an absolute ban; or as most institutions have done, they have not addressed generative AI programs at all in the academic context (Hasanein & Sobaih, 2023). Only 7% of schools worldwide report having an institutional policy or guidance regarding student AI usage (UNESCO, 2023). Following, there are ethical concerns with the created policies as educational institutions are unaware of how to address the impact of generative AI to preserve student academic integrity, as well as student learning and well-being. Furthermore, few studies have explored high school students' perspectives on ChatGPT.

Students and teachers at our own school also note the lack of a clear, standardized policy on student AI usage in the classroom. In conducting and disseminating our research on high school students' perspectives on generative AI, our goal is to fill an existing gap in the literature and to inform policy both locally and potentially on a larger scale by acting as microphones for our participants as we share their authentic perspectives. We aim to provide school administrators, educators, and even students with information to regulate AI usage in the classroom.

We approach our research with the fundamental understanding that there exist two separate spheres of thought in secondary schools that have created a chasm between each other. The first is the discourse amongst students, and the second is the discourse amongst teachers and administrators. Ideally, this study will help reinforce the communication between these two spheres. Our study was prompted by the conflict between students and teachers that we witnessed at our high school. Taking advantage of our position as student researchers, we sought to expose students' narratives regarding ChatGPT to an academic audience. Thus, our research offers a view into student perspectives that can be used to create a consensus for policy surrounding AI in secondary education.

With this research, educators and policymakers in educational institutions will be able to more holistically examine both how ChatGPT benefits students and how it may be abused. This understanding allows for the development of targeted policies to fix the ethical concern and maximize student learning and skills from their academic careers. As corroborated by Martinek et al. (2022), students ought to be encouraged to contribute to educational policy decisions. Such encouragement to interact with students at the higher policy level results in higher student participation, which contributes positively to academic performance and student well-being. Student participation in policymaking is particularly important in policies relating to new technology that can influence academic work; our study specifically addresses the pressures related to ChatGPT use in schools.

Literature Review

Literature Selection

There is currently limited research regarding the usage of ChatGPT in education. Moreover, many of these studies focus on post-secondary education. To filter research centered around secondary education, we used the search terms “ChatGPT” and “secondary education” across the databases Google Scholar, JSTOR, and EBSCO. Lastly, we identified several studies that focused on ChatGPT in high schools.

High School Education and ChatGPT

Since the release of ChatGPT in 2022, several researchers have studied the ways ChatGPT can be used in secondary educational settings. In 2023, Salmaan conducted a study on 25 students from a secondary school in Indonesia. The students were given a multiple-choice questionnaire about productivity and ChatGPT, and they were given the choice to answer on a spectrum from “Strongly Agree” to “Strongly Disagree.” The study found that students who used ChatGPT worked more productively. In the same year, Javier and Moorhouse (2023) facilitated English lessons with ChatGPT for 49 students in a public secondary school in the Philippines. They concluded that while ChatGPT could help students practice language, few knew how to do so effectively. The researchers recommended that instructors teach their students the necessary skills to use ChatGPT. Ng et al. (2024) conducted a similar study to compare the efficacy of SRLbot (a ChatGPT-based chatbot) and Nemobot (a rule-based AI) in assisting students in self-regulated learning. Seventy-four secondary school students in Hong Kong attended 10 science lessons on “force and motion.” After each lesson, students were instructed to interact with either SRLbot or Nemobot depending on which group they were assigned to. Several students from each group were later interviewed. In the interviews, students expressed a positive view on SRLbot because of its quick responses and ability to personalize both feedback and learning strategies.

Salmaan (2023), Javier and Moorhouse (2023), and Ng et al. (2024) suggested that students and teachers should utilize ChatGPT in a way that takes advantage of its benefits, such as its ability to increase productivity in students. In fact, Levine et al. (2024) found that students already use ChatGPT productively. In their study, they recruited 12 students from a charter high school in California. The researchers then conducted two after-school sessions in which the students were instructed to respond to writing prompts with the help of ChatGPT as needed. The students in the study used ChatGPT for planning out their ideas, for putting their ideas into words, and for editing their work. All four studies concluded that teachers and students should learn how to use ChatGPT more effectively in the classroom.

These studies provide insight on how high school students can use ChatGPT in classrooms; however, they lack general student perceptions of ChatGPT. Both student perspectives and data on students’ use of ChatGPT are critical in the formation of ChatGPT policies (Lee et al., 2024). Lee et al. (2024) analyzed anonymous surveys about cheating from three high schools, in which students self-reported how many times they had engaged in specific actions related to cheating on a scale from “Never” to “4 or more times.” In the surveys, students generally approved using ChatGPT to form ideas or to explain something they did not understand but regarded using ChatGPT to write a whole essay as cheating.

Waltzer et al. (2023) found similar results in a study in which 69 high school teachers and 140 high school students took an “AI Attitude Assessment.” The study found that students

viewed using ChatGPT to edit vocabulary as beneficial, while submitting work written by ChatGPT was viewed as unacceptable. Interestingly, students tended to have a positive attitude toward ChatGPT more than teachers did. The different perceptions of ChatGPT between students and teachers again highlight the importance of incorporating student perspectives into ChatGPT policies in addition to teacher perspectives. Forman et al. (2023) also explored student perspectives on ChatGPT. Seventy high school students responded to a survey with four multiple choice questions and three open response questions. The authors reported that students used ChatGPT for “academic support, social communication, and personal management, across both educational and social contexts” (Forman et al., 2023, p. 95).

These studies offered student perspectives on how students should use ChatGPT. Participants were anonymized as a way of encouraging students to respond authentically instead of giving responses that fit the expectations that others have of them as students. However, because the surveys were anonymized, the type of questions asked were limited, and there was no opportunity to ask follow-up questions. Therefore, the students’ perspectives on ChatGPT may be incomplete. There is also a lack of literature on the reasons why students would or would not choose to use ChatGPT. Students’ reasoning behind their justification or rejection of ChatGPT can guide the creation of ChatGPT policies based on student values. Our study aims to fill this gap in the literature about high school students and ChatGPT.

Authentic Engagement and Power Imbalances

Existing literature surrounding our research focus was predominantly conducted by adult researchers. This suggests that a literature gap exists in terms of researcher positionality. By conducting and analyzing student interviews as students, we aim to bridge this gap.

Our peer research approach is justified by two primary factors: power differentials and authenticity. While power imbalances exist regardless of participant age, they are particularly pronounced in studies between adult researchers and child participants (Schelbe et al., 2014). Power differentials impact many aspects of child participation, including real or perceived coercion, confidence to seek clarification, responses to data, and credibility (Schelbe et al., 2014). For instance, participants may not be comfortable with asserting authority over the researcher, such as by skipping a question or giving an answer that challenges societal expectations (Schelbe et al., 2014). By altering researcher positionality through student-to-student interviews, we address these power imbalances and attempt to eliminate the subsequent impact on the data.

Our research approach is also justified on the grounds of authenticity. Given that peer research accounts for power imbalances which may alter student expression, our method encourages closer and fuller discussion between researcher and participant; that is, we are able to achieve a more comprehensive understanding of the data (Alderson, 2001). Given these factors, we believe that a higher level of authenticity can be achieved through peer-led interviews.

Ventayen (2023) observed that students denied using ChatGPT in their work; however, he suggests that the students’ responses may be influenced by the prevalence of institutional academic integrity policies. This implies that student participants may have exhibited a response bias through fear of disciplinary action. Our study reduces this potential response bias through an informal, confidential peer-to-peer interview that does not incentivize students to respond in a manner compliant with existing regulation. Moreover, by employing a semi-structured interview format, we are better able to collect in-depth data from participants (Ruslin et al., 2022).

Contextual Influences

Our participants mainly attended a high school that is highly competitive and filled with intense levels of academic pressure (see more in “High School Context”). In environments such as these, students may experience “spillover effects” regarding stress (Shin, 2024). These are unintended consequences of an action from one person to another. Shin (2024) argued that students’ mental states may be indirectly impacted by their peers who are under high levels of stress. These negative spillover effects only magnify when such students are near one another—a scenario common throughout the fast-paced dynamic of the participants’ high school.

Furthermore, spillover can be amplified by teachers who feel under pressure themselves as they tend to pass this pressure onto their students (Martinek et al., 2022). High school students in our study are subjected to a high amount of stress, causing some to alleviate their stress through the assistance of AI. Common factors contributing to stress are further explored within our study.

The Uniqueness of this Study

In this study—carried out as a class project by two 10th grade English courses and coordinated by our teacher—we examined perspectives on ChatGPT through confidential semi-structured interviews with 24 high school students. We aimed to determine high school student perspectives on ChatGPT through a thematic discourse analysis of the interviews through the lenses of Figured Worlds (Holland et al., 1998), positioning theory (Ingram & Elliott, 2019), and social goods (Gee, 2014). Our research was conducted through student-led semi-structured interviews that provided a wide range of perspectives on the justification and rejection of ChatGPT usage. Our study aims to fill the gap in the existing literature on ChatGPT and education and draw awareness to the field from an authentic student-led perspective to influence the decisions in policymaking related to ChatGPT and similar programs in academia.

Self-Positioning

Our research began as a multi-class collaborative investigating student perspectives on ChatGPT, an issue that was relevant to us as students. During the 2022-2023 school year, after we discussed ChatGPT and plagiarism in English class, our teacher designed a thematic discourse analysis and qualitative research unit, and we created a research question that pertained to us; this resulted in an interview project on ChatGPT. Her two 10th grade Honors English classes verbally agreed and gave consent to participate in this work. Before we proceeded, our teacher sent emails to ask for our parents’ consent, and she also attained support from our school’s English department. All students participated in the initial interviewing and writing process, but anyone who did not want their work to be a part of our research was given the option to withdraw and complete a separate, but similar, class assignment. Though given this option, all students in the 10th grade class contributed to the paper.

Through our engagement, the interview project eventually developed into a class-run research project, though it remained a form of project-based learning that was based on the Massachusetts State Standards of the English Language Arts (ELA) curriculum. Our teacher, who is a trained practitioner and an education researcher, led us through the project and offered assignments that guided the research process. These assignments were graded by our teacher, although we were made aware that should we choose to not participate in the project, it would

not impact our grade. After the initial assignments, we began to assemble and edit the paper through a two-month cross-class collaboration, and our work was no longer graded. When the school year ended, a smaller group of students, who were interested in continuing their research on ChatGPT, formed the Lexington Student Research and Publication Collaborative (LSRPC). The LSRPC officially began the following school year in September and has continued into the 2024-2025 school year with the goal of refining and publishing the paper. All the student researchers involved in the LSRPC were required to receive parental consent to publish. As this process continued, our teacher followed all American Educational Research Association (2011) ethical guidelines both regarding guiding us as researchers and our participants.

High School Context

To further contextualize our educational experiences and that of our interviewees, it is important to note the high-achieving, competitive nature of our school. All student researchers and most of the participants attended the same public high school in Massachusetts. This school had over 2,000 enrolled students in the 2023 to 2024 school year and was ranked third overall in state by *U.S. News and World Report* (2024) based on the performance on Massachusetts' standardized tests, graduation rate, and graduates' readiness for college. Harvard's student newspaper, *The Crimson*, even dubbed it a "Harvard feeder-school," as it was one of the top seven most represented high schools in Harvard's undergraduate class (Bernard, 2013).

As students at this school, we perceive it to be predominantly very high achieving, with a strong emphasis on receiving high grades, taking high-level classes, and being involved in extracurricular activities. In 2017, the *New York Times* reported on the exceptionally high stress levels and suicide rates at this high school and the community's effort to combat them (Spencer, 2017). This is reflected in the biennial Youth Risk Behavior Survey taken by all the students. In 2023, 27.7% of students identified "School demands or expectations" and "Busy schedule" as the source of the most negative stress in their life. "Worrying about the future such as college, career" and "Parent/guardian or family demands or expectations about academics, grades" were the next highest, at 17.1% and 10.5%, respectively. Despite those who cited parental pressure as a stressor, 86.5% of students agreed that at least some of the pressure to perform well came from themselves (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2023).

As Student Researchers

During interviews, we were naturally positioned as fellow students with respect to our interviewees through speech acts, positions, and storylines (Slocum & Langenhove, 2004). One challenge for typical adult researchers in conducting research on high school students is the power imbalance between an adult researcher and the youth participant (Schelbe et al., 2014). The already existing power imbalance between researcher and participant is accentuated by the age difference, and the student participant may position the researcher as the authority figure (Schelbe et al., 2014; Slocum & Langenhove, 2004).

However, since we were positioned as students of similar ages alongside our participants, the effects of the power imbalance were minimized in the interviews (Schelbe et al., 2014; Slocum & Langenhove, 2004). In addition, most of our participants attended the same high school as we, so we could connect with our participants over shared experiences (Alderson, 2001). Since we were more familiar with their experiences, we were able to ask more specific questions that could reveal a fuller truth of the student perspective (Alderson, 2001). The participants may also be more comfortable sharing their perspectives, knowing that their interviewer had experienced similar situations (Alderson, 2001). Because of this, our

interviewees were able to be authentic in a way they could not have been with a differently positioned interview (i.e., if a person in a position of authority was the interviewer). Conversely, it is important to note that as student researchers, there exists the risk of confounding our own experiences with those of the participants (Alderson, 2001). To address this issue, we had multiple researchers code and analyze each interview, and we followed a structured framework to guide our analysis. We also had several researchers write and edit each section of our analysis.

Theoretical Framework

In this paper, we analyzed student discourse through the framework of Figured Worlds and positioning theory (Holland et al., 1998; Ingram & Elliott, 2019) as well as social goods (Gee, 2014).

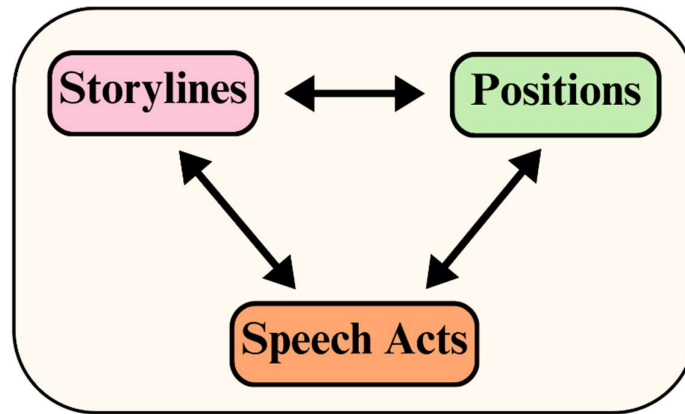
This choice of framework stems from our belief that language and values are social, and social interaction creates culture which in turn shapes identity (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). Positioning theory aligns with these beliefs as it frames speech acts as a linguistic tool that reinforces and determines an individual's position within a storyline (Slocum & Langenhove, 2004). Further, we believe that "culture" is an oversimplified term. Instead of being one, definable, monolithic entity, culture is rather a realm constructed through interaction, being multi-layered and complex. Holland et al.'s (1998) Figured Worlds satisfy these beliefs, encompassing the constructed and dynamic nature of these spheres and additionally describing the way that common values are defined within groups of people (Holland et al., 1998). Figured Worlds further consider how the constructed nature of a specific Figured World may impact its participants, particularly valuable for us as we were looking to examine our interviewees' perspectives within a specific context (Ingram & Elliott, 2019). Finally, we believe perception is as important as reality, as knowledge is constructed around an interviewee's experience rather than objective truth (Fosnot, 2005). This further underpinned our decision to choose Figured Worlds.

Similarly, when we as researchers coded the interviews during analysis, we participated in the construction of knowledge by pulling out the quotes we believed were most relevant and examined how they interacted with our framework. However, as students, we are participants in the population of interest, so our construction of the knowledge revealed by the interviews is more resonant than that of an outside researcher.

A Figured World is, in essence, the imaginary domain created when specific people interact within a specific space. The participants of the Figured World adopt positions that are associated with certain storylines and speech acts (Holland et al., 1998; Ingram & Elliott, 2019).

Such speech acts, positions, and storylines comprise positioning theory (Ingram & Elliott, 2019). When individuals interact, they use words and actions known as speech actions, and its meaning is derived from how it is used. A speech action with one of its attributed meanings is called a speech act. One speech action may have different speech acts, or meanings, depending on where it is said (the Figured World) and who says it (their position).

Figure 1
Positioning Triad



Positions are roles given to participants of a Figured World that is made up of “rights”, what others must do for an individual, and “duties,” what that individual must do for others (Ingram & Elliott, 2019, p. 29). When an individual asserts their rights and duties in an interaction, they are positioning themselves (placing themselves in a position). When they uphold the rights and duties of others, they are positioning others.

Storylines tell a narrative that relates the different positions of a Figured World to each other. In the analogy of a play, the Figured World would be the setting, the positions would be the characters, and the narrative would be the story of the play. These narratives influence the expectations of an interaction, and individuals can deduce people’s expectations by considering what narratives are present. Explicit storylines are when the positions are established, and the expectations are stated. Within a Figured World, there can be multiple storylines, including both explicit and implicit ones.

Under Gee’s (2014) framework, all discourses are oriented to achieve social goods, the values and desires of a society. Individuals position themselves to acquire the social goods of their Figured World (Gee, 2014; Holland et al., 1998).

Individuals carry their positions regardless of the Figured World they occupy, but they position themselves into their corresponding role of the Figured World they are currently in. Sometimes, the individual’s Figured Worlds may overlap when an individual’s behaviour from one Figured World influences another. When the social goods of their overlapping Figured Worlds do not coincide, the individual’s positions can conflict.

It is often in these moments that individuals develop their identity using “authoring.” Authoring is the act of “directing their own actions, managing their own feelings, and organising their own thoughts” (Holland et al., 1998, p. 281). In other words, authoring is the act of choosing without being fully dependent on one’s Figured Worlds. One way authoring is implemented is when an individual chooses between the social goods of their Figured Worlds to minimize conflict.

In this paper, we aimed to examine how the different Figured Worlds, along with the social goods, positions, and storylines related to those Figured Worlds, impact students’ ChatGPT usage in high school.

Methodology

Our Approach

To answer our research question, we utilized a nominal qualitative design (Dettori & Norvell, 2018), in which we conducted interviews and examined the transcripts through thematic discourse analysis (Ingram & Elliott, 2019). In other words, we identified main themes in our data, categorized the interviews into those themes, and then analyzed the participants' discourse within those categories. As discussed in the Theoretical Framework section, we chose a semi-structured interview format in line with our constructivist-interpretivist epistemology. This format allows the interviewee to showcase their own personal construction of truth regarding AI and education. Furthermore, coding the dialogue of the interviews through the lens of our framework, a qualitative method, enabled us to analyze relationships, such as between student and teacher, student and student, student and parent (Kershner et al., 2020).

Participants

Our first sample of interviewees was selected through an opportunity sampling method. Bell (2010) posits that since researchers rely on the availability of respondents, opportunity sampling is acceptable so long as the makeup of the sampling and limitations to the data are declared. However, it is important to note that while these interviews were selected at the researchers' convenience, the interviewees were from different social groups, as the student researchers were placed into English classes through a random scheduling system. From our original 28 interviews of students at various grade levels, we selected a final sample size of 24 based on the criteria that the students (a) attended our high school and (b) discussed ChatGPT and Generative AI in education at some point in their interviews. Omona (2013) corroborates how subsampling is an effective method in qualitative research to locate themes and information relevant to answering one's research question. With this new sub-sample, we guided our research with the assumption that our group of interviewees consisted of students at an affluent suburban public high school in Massachusetts with ~2500 students. Most participants fell between the ages of 14 and 17, and the sample comprised diverse students by race, culture, and gender. However, we chose not to include detailed background information in this article due to a lack of relevance, as well as concerns about compromising confidentiality.

Ethics

Informed to the purpose of the study and that their interview would only be used for academic purposes, participants verbally consented to participate. Furthermore, they were given the option to withdraw from the study until its dissemination.

Through our research, we pseudonymized participants' names with a random letter and deleted all interview recordings after writing transcriptions. Additionally, participants were not necessarily involved in the English course and received no compensation for their input. Regarding the interview, we refrained from discussing personal or traumatic topics, and participants were not pressured to answer questions. Interviews were conducted in low-pressure environments that would not endanger the participants (British Educational Research Association, 2018).

Data Collection

Collection Methods

Regarding our own status as researchers, in Spring 2023, 50 10th-grade English students each conducted one interview with an individual of their choice, provided that the participant was either a student, a teacher, or an expert in a field relevant to ChatGPT, to explore multiple perspectives. After we collected the interviews, we noticed that most of our data consisted of high school students, so we concentrated our research question on high school communities, specifically that of an affluent suburban public high school in Massachusetts. We discarded 4 of our 28 student interviews, keeping a total of 24 for analysis since one of the students attended a different type of high school (Participant C), and three of the students were not in high school (Participants D, J, and N). Participant R did not attend our school of focus, but we included their data nonetheless due to their experience of facing similar pressures to the rest of the participants in school, along with peers and family.

We employed a semi-structured interview approach. The use of open-ended, reflective questions allowed the interviewee to interpret the prompt within their own worldview. This allowed for the construction of their knowledge and perspective within the specific figured world formed by the interviewee and interviewer. The freedom to move at the participants' pace helped us to understand their unique perspective as fully as possible. However, the researcher's values are inevitably present in all parts of research. This is because throughout the interactions within the interview, what we perceived as the truth within the figured world was constantly being negotiated through dialogue (Guba & Lincoln, 1994). Thus, the position of the researcher is significant, as our being peers of the interviewees is uniquely valuable because we are more likely to empathize with their worldview, as opposed to an unknown adult researcher. Additionally, student researchers interviewed student participants in their location of choice to maximize the authenticity of the responses (Kvale, 1996).

One of the reasons for our large sample size of interviews was to minimize the effect of potential inauthenticity, such as falsified interviews by co-researchers in our 10th grade class. However, the student-led nature of the project encouraged high levels of classroom engagement, which in turn promoted academic integrity. Students analyzed their own interviews in an essay, which were then reviewed one-on-one with our instructor. In this review, students explained who they interviewed—while maintaining confidentiality—and their experience with the interview process. Finally, because interview analyses were marked, and per our teacher's zero tolerance ChatGPT policy, it was less likely for students to plagiarize or fabricate their own interview data.

Interview Questions

Before starting the interview process, our instructor taught student researchers interview ethics, how to create questions, and how to ask follow-up questions to maximize the interviewee's authentic perspectives. Our instructor also demonstrated these skills with a model interview.

Interviews were recorded and transcribed by student researchers and then transferred onto Google Documents; after transcription, all identifying information was removed to ensure confidentiality, and the original recordings were deleted. These steps were taken as precautions to protect the student interviewees. Due to their positionality, student researchers were taught to avoid asking leading questions and instead to focus on open-ended questions that respected

the nature of their relationships with the participants, ensuring the reliability of the data collected.

From an interview guide that contained a set of recommended questions, students were required to create their own list of questions delving into these central ones. Following a semi-structured format, our instructor taught us to follow the indicative question guide and then to allow for a participant-guided discussion with occasional redirection if the responses became tangential.

Some interviewers began their interview without discussing ChatGPT at all, instead asking general questions like, “What motivates you academically?” (interviews with participants A, E, I, R) or “What effect do grades have on your decisions?” (interviews with participants E, F, R, V, X). However, at some point in the interview, nearly every interviewer (all but interviews with participants DD, M, P, Q, W) asked their interviewees “Have you heard of ChatGPT?” or “What do you think about ChatGPT?” to gauge their interviewee’s uncurbed interpretation of this large language model. Most interviewers (all but interviews with participants P, W, and X) asked some variation of “Have you ever used ChatGPT and how?” to understand what, if any, usage of ChatGPT the participant had decided is acceptable to use. Many interviewers then transitioned to more focused questions regarding the dynamic between students and AI, such as “How does ChatGPT influence students’ development of critical thinking skills?” (interviews with participants L and W), as well as “What makes a work of art or literature ‘human’” and/or “how are ChatGPT-generated works similar or different to human-produced work?” (interviews with participants F, I, R, T, Y). A third common question presented the interviewee with a real-world application, asking, “How do you think/hope ChatGPT will be incorporated into schools in the future?” (interviews with participants AA, DD, I, K, O, U).

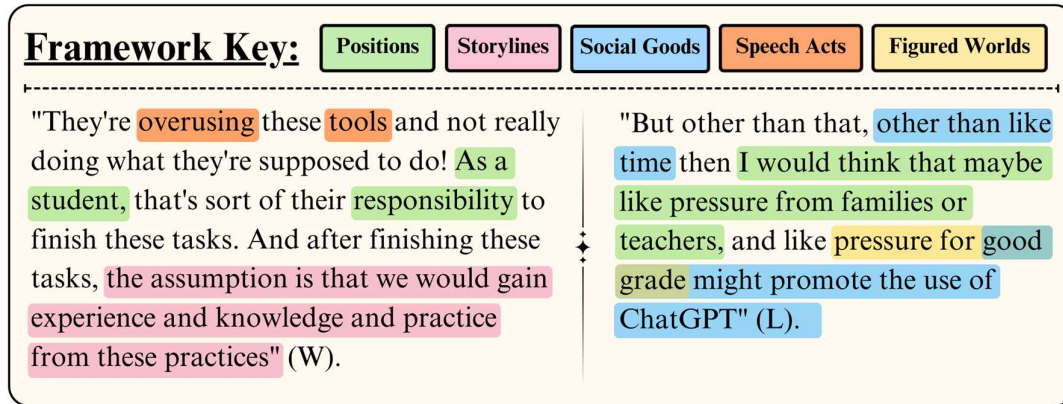
Analysis

We began the coding process in the 2022-2023 school year during which our 10th grade English course instructor guided us through structured units that culminated into individual comparative analysis essays. These essays were written based on several iterations of a discourse analysis coding we conducted as a class. However, the following school year, a small subset of passionate students (LSRPC) decided to rework the paper to establish more coherence and to delve deeper into the chosen research topics.

We discarded our previous analytical coding, and we re-coded each of the interviews with a coding scheme based on our theoretical framework, searching for themes and discourses within larger Figured Worlds (Kershner et al., 2020), highlighting instances when social goods, speech acts, positions, and storylines were apparent. Multiple researchers coded and analyzed each interview in an iterative process to ensure validity. These codes contributed to a thematic discourse analysis: by coding for social goods and pressures, we conducted a thematic analysis; by coding for speech acts, positions, and storylines—exploring “language-in-use” (Gee, 2014) and the ways participants spoke about and positioned themselves around these social goods and pressures—we conducted a discourse analysis.

When coding excerpts, we highlighted elements which pertain to the concepts of each code. For example, when examining the second paragraph, “I would think that... pressure from families or teachers” positions a student as subject to the expectations of familial and academic authority. Moreover, we see time and grades as social goods (see Figure 2). Codes such as these were kept throughout the rest of our analysis process.

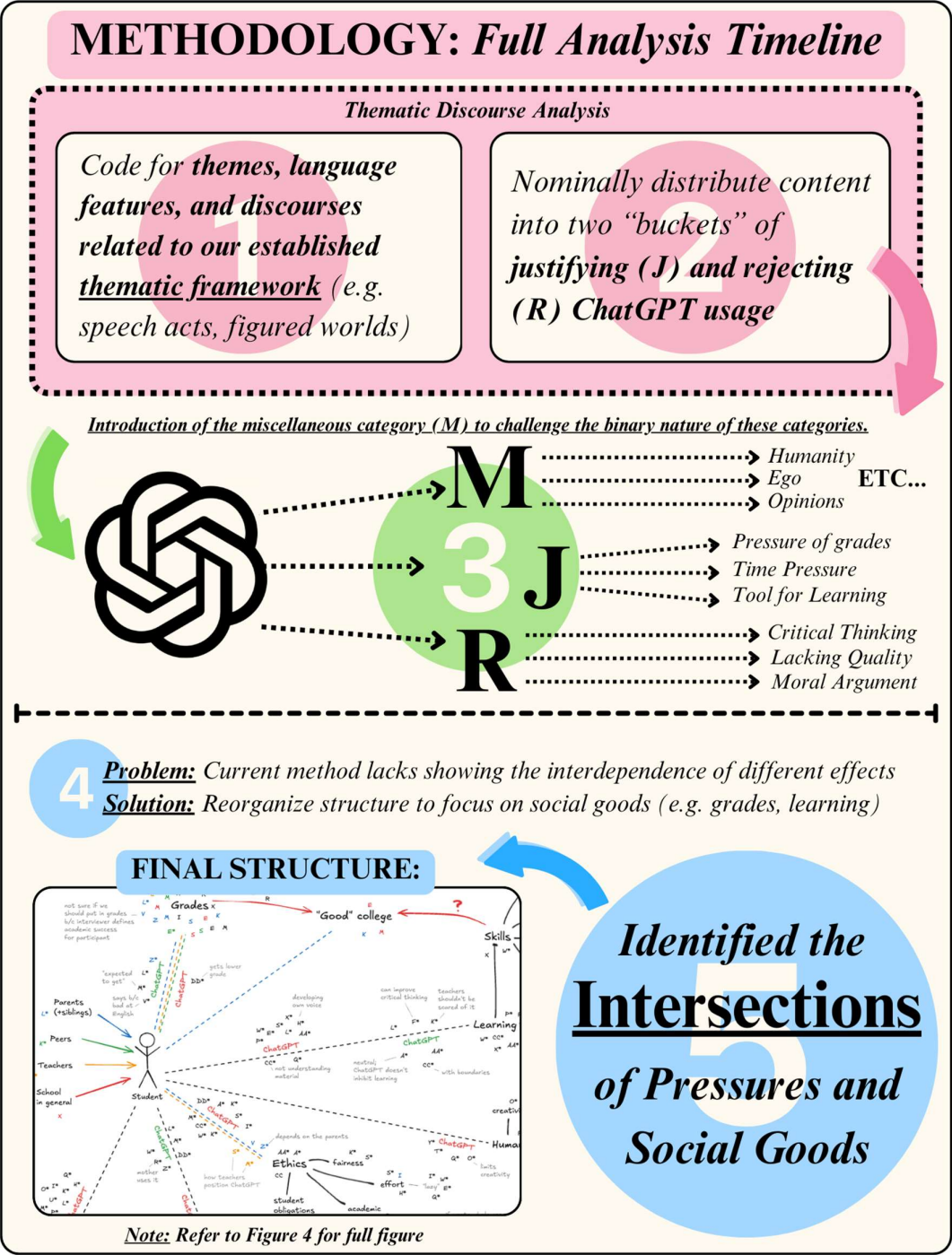
Figure 2
Framework Key Example



Separate from our previous analytical coding, we carried out a content analysis, extracting quotes from the interviews and organizing them into three categories: Justifying ChatGPT, Rejecting ChatGPT, and Miscellaneous. Taking the example of Figure 2, the quote from Participant L would be assigned to the Justifying ChatGPT category and the quote from Participant W to the Rejecting ChatGPT category. In the Miscellaneous category, we included instances when the participants discussed concepts related to our framework or to pressures, such as the social good of grades or parental pressure. However, even with a Miscellaneous category, our data did not fully conform to the binary “justifying” and “rejecting” categories, so we re-structured our analysis around the thematic concept of social goods to introduce more nuance.

Throughout the whole process, we braided together both a thematic and a discourse analysis. First, using our previous framework codes, we reviewed all the interviews and listed the social goods that were repeated throughout the interviews. The words highlighted in blue from Figure 2—“time” and “good grade”—are two examples. After we gathered all the discourse about social goods, we grouped them together into a smaller set of social goods; these served as the main themes in our analysis, which in turn structured our findings. Secondly, within each major social good theme, we identified student-reported pressures that pushed the participants to value the social good. Examples include familial pressure and teacher pressure, themes that can be found in the quote from Participant L. Thirdly, we analyzed the participants’ discourse to explore how they positioned ChatGPT within the Figured World of high school. They often described ChatGPT with adjectives, including “tool” or “cheating,” and we interpreted these speech acts and their connotations to determine whether they believed ChatGPT would help or hinder them from achieving their desired social good. These two positions—ChatGPT as an assistor or inhibitor—were then respectively labeled “Justifying ChatGPT Usage” and “Rejecting ChatGPT Usage.” Gee (2014) defined discourse as “language ... used in specific contexts” (19). In our analysis, the specific contexts consisted of themes (i.e., social goods and pressures), and we studied how students’ discourse interacted with and within these themes.

Figure 3
Timeline and Evolution of Thematic Discourse Analysis



To ensure validity when analyzing discourse, Gee (2014) emphasizes the analysis of linguistic details, specifically grammar and the meaning it conveys (i.e., speech acts). Moreover, Kiwi Tamasese (Tamasese & Denborough, 2024) posits that in certain forms of

qualitative research, validity is not necessarily founded on objective observation, but in connections with the participants to engender a more thorough analysis. By analyzing discourse and themes, we sought to analyze how the participants interpreted ChatGPT in the high school context. As students who are members of the population of interest, our interpretations of the participants' interpretations align more closely than that of an outside researcher. Nevertheless, it is important to note that all discourse analysis is an interpretation, and thus is always "open to further discussion and dispute" (Gee, 2014, p. 141).

ChatGPT as a tool—one that can grant access to previously unattainable social goods but may also pose threats to students long-term. While it is inaccurate to accept the binary of a simple acceptance or rejection of ChatGPT, we found that students' association of ChatGPT with the attainment of certain social goods informed the ways in which they positioned its acceptability for either themselves or their peers. Moreover, we also found that the social goods themselves were shaped by the pressures students faced in their various Figured Worlds. Thereby, the intersection of pressures and social goods influenced the ways in which students defined acceptable and unacceptable ChatGPT usage.

Generally, students prioritized certain social goods over others, yet they sometimes reordered their priority of influence depending on the Figured World they were in. We structured our analysis around the six social goods that were repeatedly mentioned across numerous interviews: high grades, learning, efficiency, ethics, humanity, and superiority. Within each social good section, we identify pressures in the Figured World of our high school and the ways in which those pressures, in conjunction with the participants' valorization of the social good, influenced their justification or rejection of ChatGPT usage.

Lastly, as a final section called "Snapshots," we examine three individual participant narratives that emphasized the interplay between different social goods. Despite our larger sample size, we chose to deep dive into Participants S, DD, and I to investigate their unique discussion of many social goods. Our student-to-student connection with our participants allowed us to become microphones for them, amplifying their complex experiences. This also allowed for us to engage with the more nuanced facets of the student experience.

High Grades

In the Figured World of a high-achieving high school, students perceived grades as a central social good. When asked about their end goal of completing schoolwork, Participant R responded, "grades are pretty important." Similarly, Participant E observed that "people focus on grades a lot." Participant H also perceived grades as a social good, stating, "academic success definitely varies from person to person, but for me personally, (pause) um, I'd say, for me, it's getting (chuckle) good grades probably." Here, Participant H spells out that they define academic success as "good grades"—a speech act repeated by Participant A when they say that their motivations in school are "getting good grades, doing well in school," implying that "doing well" is synonymous with receiving high grades.

Participants DD, H, L, M, S, and Z indicated that parents and guardians were a source of pressure to be academically successful. For these students, grades were highly valued within the Figured World of the home, shaping their perception of success for the future. As a result, they carried this value into other Figured Worlds within the school. Participant DD, for example, noted that when completing assignments, they were aware that "[the grade] parents want, like, is A+." This underscores how parental emphasis on high grades reinforces a sense of obligation in children to meet these expectations. In turn, this obligation shapes the student's storyline, positioning academic achievement as a primary goal.

This focus on grades directly connects to college admissions. Participants E and R explained that they believe grades are a platform to "get into a good school" (E), implying a desire for a prestigious post-secondary education. The repeated expressions of desire for their children to attend elite colleges by parents appeared to heighten academic insecurity for some students.

Peers also played a role in driving the need for academic validation for our participants. Participants M and S had both experienced indirect pressure from peers and the school environment to obtain high grades. Participant M described how the behavior of their friends

who “value[d] themselves on their academic achievements or grades” affected their mindset, as they wondered: “Are they thinking of me in the same way?” Participant S believed a similar idea, stating that their “classmates also kinda expect [them] to be getting good grades.” Due to their position as students, both Participants M and S believed that their peers expected them to value grades as a social good.

These students brought the social good of grades from an exterior Figured World—that of their parent-to-child and peer-to-peer dynamics—to the inner classroom Figured World.

Justifying ChatGPT

Improves Grades. Many of these students defended the use of ChatGPT because of its potential to positively impact their grades. For instance, through their speech acts, students emphasized ChatGPT’s ability to comprehensively answer questions. One student stated that they “think it is very useful” because it is “very, very thorough” (CC). ChatGPT could provide personalized assistance based on a student’s particular needs, allowing them to better grasp the material necessary for the achievement of high grades (A, AA, S). This increased the accessibility and lessened the barrier for students to achieve this social good.

Even some participants who did not condone AI use for schoolwork understood how a student might justify using ChatGPT given how grades were a social good. Participant Z, for example, stated that “if someone has parents... pressuring them to get A’s, the student is most likely to use ChatGPT to improve their grades.”

Another participant, Participant M, expressed that the pressure of grades was a common driving factor in ChatGPT use, saying that if there is a student who is “not doing too well, and there is something that can do it for them and make them get the grades they’re expected to get, then obviously they’d use it. Like, who wouldn’t?” Participant M’s example highlights how students who view ChatGPT as being effective in improving grades may justify the use of ChatGPT. For students who believe in ChatGPT’s ability to improve grades, it falls neatly in line with the goals of a student because grades are upheld as a social good for students in multiple spheres (the home, with peers, and at school).

Rejecting ChatGPT

Worsens Grades. Other students held an alternative perspective of ChatGPT. They believed it was an ineffective tool to improve students’ grades. Participant M, for example, recalled a time in which they had used ChatGPT to write a history essay and thought, “I cannot submit something like this”—they deduced that ChatGPT’s essay would not meet their teacher’s requirements. When the teachers’ expectations of the students are not met, students fail to acquire the social good of grades. This notion was also recognized by Participant DD, who posited that ChatGPT “doesn’t get you, you know, a [sic] ideal grade,” and the work ChatGPT produced could not grant the academic achievement of an “A or an A+.” Both students ultimately concluded that ChatGPT’s work was ineffective as a tool to achieve the social good of high grades.

Learning

Learning was defined by our participants as the acquisition of knowledge, critical thinking skills, work ethic, and writing proficiency. According to Participant W, students have a responsibility to learn as well as “gain experience and knowledge and practice.” Similarly, Participant X ties the “education system” to learning soft skills, like “managing stress,

managing your time, [and] being able to do things even if you don't want to do them.” Thus, the social good of learning is closely tied to academic Figured Worlds.

Many students believed that learning would lead to future success in college, which provided an internal motivation to develop intellectually. Participant S stated that “it’s just better to do the work when you need to as a student,” and that “how you work as a student will be how you work as an adult or in college.” Participant S implicitly framed the “work of a student” as leading to the acquisition of skills to use in future endeavors like college. They emphasize student learning as a key aspect of a student’s storyline to attain success. Participant R established this connection explicitly, claiming that “the real benefit of learning is the practicality and how much you’ll actually use this in life,” spotlighting the value of the knowledge acquired through schooling. This storyline to success, and the role that acquired knowledge plays therein, is what pressures students to value learning.

Justifying ChatGPT

Tool to Assist Learning. Some students portrayed ChatGPT as a tool that actively facilitates learning. Participant S referenced ChatGPT’s ability to provide efficient summaries of topics, stating that could help students acquire more information “if they want an explanation on a topic.” Participant CC also identifies this use of ChatGPT, noting its capacity to condense information into “a couple of paragraphs, so you can get a general idea.” Here, our participants paint ChatGPT as conducive to learning concrete information. However, other students drew additional connections between the use of ChatGPT and the development of skills like critical thinking. Participant F stated that “it’s a great tool to help not only improve your critical thinking but to help you solidify your previous knowledge.” Here they not only established a link between learning in the dimension of knowledge but also the dimension of skill. For these students, ChatGPT had the potential of playing a constructive role in a student’s learning storyline. They were thus more likely to accept the use of ChatGPT as an educational tool.

Search Engine. Students also interpret ChatGPT to be a resource that helps facilitate learning with more comprehensive approaches compared to that of a traditional search engine. Participants describe it as “Wikipedia, but like, more dynamic” (A) & framing it as a resource comparable to online search engines. Many students utilized it “as a background knowledge tool” to enable, rather than undermine, learning (A). Participants claimed that by “reflecting on what ChatGPT is doing different[ly] from [them],” their critical thinking was enhanced and their knowledge solidified (F). Through this lens, the usage of ChatGPT is justified; it is perceived as a tool that helps foster understanding of content, which directly results in higher grades.

Rejecting ChatGPT

Obstruction to Learning. Several participants viewed ChatGPT as an obstruction to learning. Participant CC expressed their fear that generative AI undermined a student’s understanding of class material. When asked to outline the negative aspects of ChatGPT in an educational context, they describe the use of ChatGPT as “another form of cheating” where “you’re not understanding the material.” Participant CC is positioned as a student within the Figured World of our high school and thus has an implicit understanding that “you [as a student] want to absorb what you’re learning” (CC). Participant H expands the discussion of the negative aspects of ChatGPT to include skill, pointing out that ChatGPT may prevent the development of a unique writing style. When asked about the problematic aspects of ChatGPT,

they stated that “as a high schooler, like, I, um, like especially in English class, I’m trying to find my own voice” (Participant H). This participant implicates learning and the development of a unique voice in their valuation of ChatGPT, conceptualizing it as a blockage to the acquisition of skill. Similarly, Participant P alluded to the negative long-term consequences of using AI on the capacity to fulfill the student role of learning through assignments; “you kind of build those habits of not doing schoolwork.”

Success Beyond High School. The students who view ChatGPT negatively emphasize the importance of learning and success. This is made explicit by Participant BB, who explained through a hypothetical situation: “Let’s just say I want to be a doctor... I’m in med school, I use ChatGPT for, like, all my essays, or like, research papers, I’m not going to learn anything myself, and so how can I be a doctor?” Participant BB re-emphasizes the link between learning and professional success. They positioned ChatGPT as fundamentally incompatible with both knowledge and skill, thus blocking their pathway within the student’s storyline.

Different Perspective

Aside from those who associated ChatGPT with a particular positive or negative connotation, one student believed that ChatGPT did not significantly impact the learning process at all. Participant A expressed that the conversation surrounding ChatGPT “put focus on the wrong topics,” and they did not believe that the frequent use of ChatGPT would diminish the “importance of school.” The participant believes that ChatGPT has little to no potential to impact the student’s learning storyline, implying that learning plays a lesser role in their justification or negation of ChatGPT use.

Efficiency

Approximately half of the participants valued efficiency as a social good. Among this subset of students, they used terms like “efficient,” “saves time,” “faster,” “quicker,” “convenience,” and “easier” in their interviews, implying that the participants associated the use of ChatGPT with attaining the social good of reducing the time and effort spent on tasks (DD, H, K, L, M, P, R, S, T, V, W, X, Z).

The pressure to be efficient mainly stemmed from students’ need to balance many activities. For example, Participant DD was expected to play sports, engage in extracurricular activities, and get A-range grades at school. Because of this, Participant DD needed to complete an overwhelming workload in a small amount of time, and “it just becomes pretty hard to balance all the stuff” (DD). To keep up, busy high school students must be conscious of their time management—and are thus pressured to be efficient.

Justifying ChatGPT

When questioned during the interview, each of the participants who indicated that they valued efficiency agreed that using ChatGPT could help them. Participants DD, L, T, K, H, W, and R justified using ChatGPT because “it would just save so much time” (K). Of the seven participants, Participants K, H, W, and R framed saving time as inherently vital to their lives, while Participants D, L, and T wished to save time to do other activities.

Lacking Time. Participant DD, the only participant who reported having written essays with ChatGPT, cited lack of time as their main reason for using it. They explained, “As a student, it becomes really hard to get all these essays in with, you know, the amount of time

that I have after playing sport[s]” (DD). In other words, Participant R viewed ChatGPT as “a tool for convenience.” Participant DD said, referencing their past habits, that they “will probably continue to use Chat GPT, just because it's so easy to use” and because “I can make it easier and faster for myself.” Participant DD positioned themselves as both an athlete and a student. Saving time allowed them to fulfill their athletic obligations and responsibilities while still completing schoolwork, thereby maintaining both positions. Participants appeared to be disposed to use ChatGPT in the face of menial tasks, with Participants DD and R both having a positive view of using ChatGPT to “do all this extra busywork that teachers assign” (DD). Because of ChatGPT’s efficient generative abilities, students see the potential it has as a tool to alleviate the more difficult aspects of their positions in their overlapping Figured Worlds.

Teacher Assistance. However, students do not only portray ChatGPT as a tool for the maintenance of their own positions within educational figured worlds, but also as a tool for teachers to efficiently uphold their positions as educators. Participant W suggested that teachers could be “more efficient” by asking “an AI to generate prompts” for class material. Similarly, Participant R stated that their mother, who is a tutor, had ChatGPT “write down questions ... just to get it done quicker.” Indeed, it seems that some students view ChatGPT as a universal tool for anyone to fulfill their position with less effort.

Rejecting ChatGPT

Minor Usage at Most. Despite many students expressing that ChatGPT could be beneficial for efficiency, most students still refused to use it for academic work. Participant R expressed a positive view of using ChatGPT for small tasks—such as asking questions and finding information—but not for “creating an end product,” implying that they felt hesitancy toward using the tool unrestricted, likely due to ethical concerns or administrative consequences. Participant L followed a similar line of thought. Although they stated that they rejected the use of ChatGPT, they understood the appeal of “being more efficient and saving time” to be “able to do other things outside of school” (L). It appears that, from an efficiency standpoint, most students agreed that ChatGPT has the potential to be a useful tool. Students who ultimately leaned toward rejecting ChatGPT were likely influenced by the pursuit of other social goods that they valued to a greater degree than efficiency, such as ethics or work quality.

Ethics

Participants determined ethics to be a social good, defined in this context as the quality of producing work through the student’s original thought. Students strive to be ethical due to societal pressures to produce authentic work. Participant S emphasized that students using ChatGPT “can, like, get a whole essay in a few minutes without any effort, which again is, like, plagiarizing something off the internet” (S). In this context, the speech act “plagiarizing” positions students who use ChatGPT as cheaters who fall below Participant S’ standards of morality. Students doing this can attain the same or better grades than those who wrote their essay authentically, which “decreases fairness” (S).

Several external sources including teachers, school administration, and even general news and media teach from a young age that moral integrity and academic honesty are integral social goods. This narrative thus positions the student as morally bound to truthfulness and ethicality, framing independent work and personal achievement as integral responsibilities of their role.

Since ChatGPT's release, however, these same sources have promoted the narrative that the usage of AI equates to cheating, thus framing it in a conflict with acquiring the social good of ethicality. Some of our participants internalize this narrative, creating an individual aversion to ChatGPT.

However, this narrative is also reinforced externally. We see this reflected in the interviews, with Participant Z stating the main reason they decline to use ChatGPT was due to potential administrative consequences. In our high school, for example, some of our teachers have implemented policies such as signing honor pledges directed towards AI use, using programs that track document history, and threatening an automatic zero if AI is detected. Participant M describes another strategy in which their teacher made them "write a whole essay by hand" to ascertain they were not using ChatGPT.

Each of our participants who mentioned ethicality or integrity did so in the context of ChatGPT being unethical, so none of our participants discussed an ethical justification for the usage of AI to complete schoolwork.

Rejecting ChatGPT

Participants' use of ethics was mainly as a reason to reject ChatGPT usage, perceiving it as ethically wrong. This "moral argument" can be attributed to three domains: plagiarism, unfairness, and student responsibility.

Cheating and Plagiarism. Primarily, students considered the output of generative AI as a form of plagiarism. When asked about using ChatGPT in academic work, several participants (M, V, and CC) exemplified the speech act of "cheating." Participants M and V specified that they viewed it as a form of plagiarism. This recurrence underscores the widespread adoption of the perception that generative AI usage is a form of academic dishonesty.

In a teacher-student discourse, one of the duties teachers expect of their students is that the work they produce is original and self-produced. Thus, when our participants rejected the usage of ChatGPT and instead opted to write essays themselves, they positioned themselves as "good students" by meeting teacher expectations.

Unfairness. Secondly, students felt that the use of ChatGPT to produce academic work offers an unfair advantage to students who use the program. Participants A and K both said that students who create their work using ChatGPT do not truly earn their grades. Participants AA and DD reflected that using ChatGPT would make them feel self-conscious about submitting inauthentic work. Participant AA suggested that the guilt of using ChatGPT is a sufficient deterrent to its use, saying, "I...don't think I would be able to submit something from ChatGPT without overthinking it and feeling guilty" (AA). These students feel they can only attain the social good of grades by following the teacher's intended manner of completing schoolwork. The participants' internal opposition to submitting inauthentic work similarly positions themselves as students who manifest teacher expectations as a personal standard to be a "good student."

This mindset of unfairness also violates their position as students. If students cannot undergo this effort, they fail to complete the storyline laid out for them as students. This loss can leave some with a sense of guilt because they violated their own position in the learning process. The guilt of students who use ChatGPT relates to an "unfair advantage" because students recognize that they are not using sufficient effort to submit their work. Thus, they feel they are not completing their storyline as a student, given their goal is to learn from authentic effort in their schoolwork, guided by the Figured World they are in.

Humanity

Participants identified humanity as a social good, defined by participants as an individual's "own intelligence or emotions" (Q), and how originality is distinctly human. Participant S specifically defined originality as "what makes us our own selves, and not just copies of other people."

A subset of participants rejected ChatGPT usage based on preserving humanity. This group of students—consisting of Participants O, Q, Y, S, I, and T—valued upholding the unique intelligence and emotions that humans possess above the assistance of ChatGPT. Among the participants who considered humanity as a means for rejecting ChatGPT usage, we identified two primary student justifications: originality and human authenticity.

Even so, through our framework, we were unable to deduce the pressures that informed this social good, as participants primarily discussed humanity in intrinsic terms rather than in response to external pressures. This limits deeper analysis in this context; consequently, we have flagged it as an area for further research.

Additionally, for all the participants who mentioned humanity, artificiality, emotions, and feelings when discussing ChatGPT, they did so in the context of AI usage in school reducing humanity. Thus, no students justified ChatGPT usage in the context of humanity.

Rejecting ChatGPT

Originality. Several students within this subset cited concerns with the originality of ChatGPT-generated work, arguing that the generated responses lack the individuality and creativity that would otherwise exist in human-created writing. Participant Q reflects this sentiment, contending that in relying on ChatGPT when writing, students may inadvertently lose or alter their own inner voice. They offer an analogy, stating, "It's like my favorite authors. If they lost their originality, people wouldn't like them as much as they do now" (Q). Similarly, Participant Y argues that human writing contains unique characteristics and mannerisms that are unreplicable through artificial intelligence. These students admire human works for their originality and thus reject the use of AI that generates texts that lack the unique stylization of quality human work.

Human Authenticity. When referring to humanity, students conveyed the idea of the capacity to facilitate human connection through the production of human thought. Participants used words and phrases such as "mimic" and "falls flat" to emphasize AI's inherent artificiality, stating that it is "not a genuine human being," and "cannot express" feelings and emotions, nor convey sincerity (S, O). Participants emphasized that despite AI's capabilities, it is "still artificial anyways," (S) indicating that although the information may accomplish the given task, it lacks human creativity and is, at best, a crude imitation. Participants stressed that AI-generated work could never match work written by a person because "the human is the one experiencing things" (I). The usage of such words implied that students associated the usage of AI with works that are unoriginal and do not convey human thoughts or experiences. The value for human authenticity motivated students to pursue the development of their own style of writing and work, thus resulting in student rejection of AI assistance in schoolwork.

Superiority

A recurring social good that arose among interviewees who primarily rejected the use of ChatGPT was the concept of individual superiority to the AI. This group consisted of Participants DD, H, I, K, L, M, R, and S. Within this subset of participants, students used three main warrants to justify their superior position to the program: (a) the fear of developing a dependence on ChatGPT at the sacrifice of academic success with assignments in which the use of AI is impossible, (b) the idea that individual work is higher quality than ChatGPT generated content, and (c) the belief that they do not need assistance from ChatGPT.

Students cited various pressures when considering the superiority of student work against that generated by ChatGPT. Some students, such as I and S, claimed that people should perform to the best of their ability, and that parents (I) or peers (S) should hold them accountable to do this. With this goal in mind, Participant I believed that pressure from parents is “usually good” and prevents students from “slack[ing] off.” Similarly, Participant S cited “competition between classmates” (i.e., the peer pressure to do as well as others) as a motivator to achieving academic validation.

Justifying ChatGPT

Students Produce Inferior Quality of Work. In the Figured World of the classroom, academic success is highly valued and creates competition among students. If students witness peers utilizing ChatGPT in their schoolwork without consequences, they will be more likely to use AI as well. Participant S states that even if they were to “work hard” they would still be “beaten out” by “better quality” writing produced by students who utilized ChatGPT, which makes them wonder if they should just use it too. They considered that work done by ChatGPT could be of a higher quality and thus understand that there exists a pressure to use AI—assuming their work will otherwise be inadequate in comparison.

Rejecting ChatGPT

Avoiding Dependence. Several students identified that building a dependence on ChatGPT ultimately hinders their academic performance, despite a short-term gratification for assignments. Participant H ties this to relieving pressures from parents to garner good grades, but at the expense of performing well in class. They describe an example storyline of such a student saying:

“Hey, I got a good grade on this [assignment], maybe my parents are going to be happy, my family is going to be happy.” But then you’re going to see a big drop (gestures big drop) when you have to end up doing something in class. (H)

Similarly, Participants H, I, K, and L are wary that the academic relief that students attain from using ChatGPT in school would not carry over into settings such as standardized tests, such as the Advanced Placement tests, as Participant K noted, and post-secondary education (Participant H references medical school). Overall, students thought that depending on ChatGPT would decrease their ability to produce quality work by their own merit, implying that they believe human effort in schoolwork is the superior method to achieve long-term success.

Lower Quality of Work. Several students perceived the quality of work produced by ChatGPT to be lower than that of their own work, suggesting that they would attain higher

grades from completing their schoolwork independently. Participant DD had explicitly stated that ChatGPT-generated texts “wouldn't give you, like, the academic success of like an A or an A+” (DD). Participants M, N, O, Q, I, R and U all corroborated that the writing quality of ChatGPT was “so rigid, and like, almost bad, and just, like, not my style” (U), and generally was of a lower caliber than the students held their own work to. The students who affirmed the lack of quality for the platform's work tended to value grades and were willing to invest additional time in their work to achieve academic validation, rather than risk lower marks.

No Need for Assistance. Participants I and S asserted that they had no need for further assistance from ChatGPT in the first place. They believed that the status quo was manageable without it. When prompted to explain how they might get help with schoolwork, Participant S explained, “I try to look at past materials to see if we went over things like this during class, but, uhm, if I don't really understand the, like, concept, I'll try to ask my parents if they understand. My main thing is to try to figure it out myself.” While S does have a system for getting the help they need with schoolwork, they are motivated to work through their struggles themselves. Despite facing parental and peer pressures to succeed in school and beyond, Participant S remained adamant about developing independent study habits. Participant I also managed their schoolwork alone. When asked why they do not use ChatGPT, they said “I just never felt the need to use it. I could handle school by myself” (I). These two participants insisted on the individual completion of schoolwork without the assistance of AI tools. These students represent a population of students who can manage the pressures of school independently from AI tools like ChatGPT.

Snapshots

As we coded interviews, multiple participants expressed unique insights into the implications of ChatGPT, social goods, and pressures within education. We chose to create a Snapshots section of our analysis to highlight those participants who brought enriching viewpoints that exposed the complexity inherent within student worlds. We hope that the exploration of the minutiae within these cases inspires further research.

Participant S: The Pensive Philosopher

Participant S discussed almost every single social good mentioned across our entire data set. They value the external validation from achieving the social good of grades, describing how, as a student, “you tend to like, compare yourself to how other people are doing, and it feels good if you're doing like better.” Although grades were frequently associated with success due to the competitive academic environment of this high school, Participant S did not appear to prioritize grades the most—instead they offered a nuanced view on other types of social goods. Swiftly rejecting the definition of success as grades that so many of our other interviewees underscored, they posited that “*learning something new is always a sign that you're improving as a student I think*, so that should count as success, right?” (emphasis added). But perhaps most intriguing is Participant S' concern for the future of humanity and ChatGPT. The very first time the interviewer asked about ChatGPT, Participant S responded, “In my opinion [ChatGPT] can be harmful to use for education or work because then soon humans don't really need to think for themselves anymore.” They then went on to state that despite AI's growing prevalence in schools and the workplace, “it's better to still do things yourself because that's what makes us our own selves ... *AI may be intelligence but it's still artificial anyways*” (emphasis added). In Participant S' worldview, the social goods of

individuality and ability to think independently overshadow the social good of grades, so even though ChatGPT might help a student achieve a certain grade, the fact that it could detract from the user's internal development outweighs the benefits, resulting in Participant S' rejection of ChatGPT.

Participant DD: The Juggler

Participant DD also valued both long-term learning and grades as a social good—except unlike Participant S, they did not have the capacity to keep both afloat. When asked about their motivation in high school, they responded “I do still feel motivated to write my own essays, because I want to help myself and I want to improve, *it's just very hard to balance being a student athlete, having extracurriculars, having a social life, and a family life*” (emphasis added). Overloaded with pressures and social goods they are expected to achieve with limited time, Participant DD is presented with a barrier that prevents them from accomplishing their goals. ChatGPT, however, presents an alternative path—one that allows them to turn in assignments, assuage baseline parental expectations, and still retain time for themselves outside of school. But everything is not as perfect as it may seem; it does come with a cost. Participant DD noted that assignments using ChatGPT often receive “a lower grade versus when [they] just write it [themselves],” which is not “the ideal grade that parents want.” Moreover, their moral compass wavered, admitting that they “*do feel guilty whenever [they] use ChatGPT,*” indicating cognitive dissonance (emphasis added). However, for Participant DD, dedicating the time to writing assignments themselves would mean giving up the social good they value most—time for their extracurricular activities—so they accepted these drawbacks.

Participant I: The Self-Sustaining Student

Participant I used the word “lazy” four times in their interview and “slack off” once—all to describe the act of using ChatGPT to write essays. This repetitive speech act positions students who use ChatGPT in a negative light: as slackers who do not care about putting in the work. They also establish a strong work ethic as a social good in a high-achieving academic environment, particularly our high school. Although they clearly value this speech act, it is not clear from the interview whether this value stems from an internal standard of hard work or from a desire to be externally perceived as hardworking as the interview did not contain any reference to pressures and motivation.

Regardless of the motivation, Participant I stated that “*overusing [ChatGPT in essay writing] can definitely make you lazy,* [and] stop caring about assignments,” (emphasis added) revealing that they believe ChatGPT is not only a sign of laziness but a perpetrator of it. Thus, Participant I strongly associates ChatGPT usage in school with lacking a proper work ethic. That notion seems to inform their decision not to use ChatGPT.

When asked what motivates them academically, their first response was that they “want good grades”—highlighting their personal importance of grades as a social good. With that, they also cite that they have no true reason for wanting good grades, they simply want them. Participant I also confidently assured the interviewer they can “handle school by [themselves]” and achieve the grades they want without ChatGPT assistance.

Interestingly, Participant I still empathizes with students in this gray area. When asked if they would use ChatGPT in a hypothetical situation under time pressure, they responded with “I do have procrastination problems, but usually I don't have to resort [to ChatGPT]. But if the time was really that bad, I guess it... it's possible I would use it, but I would probably do every single other possible thing first,” such as getting an extension or even turning it in late and accepting the point deduction because, they repeat, “*ChatGPT is the super lazy method*”

(emphasis added). Willing to take a small point deduction over using ChatGPT, Participant I stays true to their beliefs about ChatGPT—however, even students as ethically consistent as Participant I can succumb to the appeal of ChatGPT when faced with extreme pressures.

Implications, Recommendations, and Limitations

Implications and Recommendations

Teachers

The two foremost influential Figured Worlds on students came from their families and peers, whereas school remained tertiary; however, our study still offers findings useful for individual teacher policy regarding ChatGPT. An emphasis on learning and improvement enhances student engagement. This fosters motivation because students must actively implement feedback from one assignment to another. With this, teachers should ensure that students understand how assignments apply to the world and the future to incentivize authentic learning rather than short-term memorization. Some potential curricular design methods may include increasing the amount of time students have to complete an assignment, as well as process learning pedagogies (e.g., segmenting a larger assignment into individual parts).

We have formulated a standardized email template that teachers could incorporate when a student is suspected of ChatGPT usage, as follows:

Table 1

ChatGPT Email Template

Dear Student,
This is a standardized email. If you are receiving this email, your assignment was flagged for plagiarism/AI use by the following criteria:

- AI checker and plagiarism checker*
- Document history*
- Student writing sample*

This email is not a definitive claim or accusation that you cheated. Let's set up a time to meet during a study hall, lunch, or before/after school. If you did not plagiarize/use AI, then you have nothing to worry about, and I am here to work with you to figure this out. If we find that this assignment was plagiarized/AI written, you will have to redo the assignment.
Please get back to me with a good meeting time for you.

Sincerely,

District and School Policy

Insofar as school district policy implications, we posit four points: student awareness, effective use, standardized protocols, and disciplinary efforts.

1. Student Awareness. Administrators should aim to ensure that high schoolers understand how ChatGPT will impact their development as students. If educational institutions can expose the ways in which ChatGPT hinders student development and learning, students are more likely to think critically about how they can use the technology without disrupting the learning process. Further, schools can emphasize the social goods which tend toward cautioned usage of ChatGPT, such as ethics, learning, and superiority, rather than grades and efficiency. The focus on these social goods may not replace the heavy societal obsession with grades and efficiency that already exists but could act as a counter narrative.

2. Effective Use. It is reasonable to incorporate generative AI into schools and we believe that there are major benefits in educating students how to use it effectively, although only in a way that highlights learning (e.g., critical thinking, soft skills) and personal growth (e.g., developing one's own writing voice). Many of the students that we interviewed avoided ChatGPT, or if they did use it, usually only for specific parts of the writing process (e.g., brainstorming, researching, editing). Thus, policies must clearly define when it is acceptable, or not, to use ChatGPT.

3. Standardization and Protocols. We found that schools need to standardize discussions about AI in English education in school curricula. Examples include a presentation made by either the school, English department, or an AI board that all English teachers present to their students to ensure that the same expectations are being shared to all classrooms instead of a smorgasbord of different policies. Such a presentation could discuss the possible risks that ChatGPT poses to education and why teachers are so cautious about it. It could also offer a demonstration about ChatGPT's potential uses weighed with the ways in which it can perpetuate misinformation and "hallucinate" to show the dangers of not thinking critically about the information you consume.

4. Disciplinary Procedures. Finally, we recommend a standardized grade deduction for use of ChatGPT on essays; we found that threats of administrative consequences were effective in deterring some students from using ChatGPT.

Limitations

The primary limitation was the time constraint. Due to the nature of our being students of an English class at the start of the project, we were limited to meeting only three to four hours per week, and even so, we had other academic and extracurricular commitments (i.e., other classes, sports, clubs) which diverted the time we were able to spend on compiling our research. The initial lack of communication between the two English classes working on the project hindered the progress of the work in the earlier stages, but this was overcome through representatives from either class communicating directly with each other to convey the direction of the work. After the 2022-2023 school year ended, fewer of us continued the project, and we met less frequently and only for one hour per week, although frequency of meetings increased for the 2023-2024 and 2024-2025 school years, in which we met for two to four hours each week, in addition to asynchronous work and throughout the summer. A secondary limitation was the nature of our data set. Our participants were drawn through an opportunity sampling method by students who attended an Honors English class, potentially overrepresenting students who would be more likely to take an advanced English class. Consequently, our data is not generalizable to the larger population of our high school.

Conclusion

Ultimately, our participants often felt positioned by the academic world around them; their decision to use or not use ChatGPT as a tool for agency rested on which social goods were most important for them to obtain, and the extent to which it would improve their position. Our research fell at the intersection of social goods, pressure, and ChatGPT. The ways in which these features layered informed the extent to which students positioned generative AI use in school as beneficial or detrimental. From our participants, five primary social goods emerged: high grades, learning, efficiency, ethics, humanity, and superiority; by considering the pressures that influenced these goods, students determined the ways in which they would position ChatGPT. We found that the ways in which our sample of students justify or reject ChatGPT are based on the extent to which they perceive ChatGPT as a tool for movement and agency within their positioned Figured Worlds.

For example, if a hypothetical student were positioned as a “bad student” in the World of the English classroom due to their nonadherence to cultural scripts—these may include language, dress, behaviours, learning profiles, a lack of academic success— they might view ChatGPT as a way to confront and overcome their negative image (i.e., change their positioning, and obtain the necessary social good, “good grades”). They may want this due to parental pressures to find admittance to an elite university. With this, the layering of Worlds is a complex system, not a vacuum; there are other pressure-oriented storylines that can challenge their use of ChatGPT, like family culture, friends, and general morals and ethics. This student, for example, may choose to utilize ChatGPT as a study tool instead of plagiarizing, depending on where the pressures derive.

Participants’ justifications of using ChatGPT included the social goods of acquiring high grades, enriching learning, developing critical thinking, saving time, and independence. However, participants dismissed ChatGPT due to concerns over poor output quality, not understanding classroom material, stunting critical thinking, AI’s ethical uncertainty, loss of humanity and originality, or dependence on AI. We concluded that our participants’ decisions to either justify or reject using ChatGPT were determined by their positions in academic storylines. These positions were influenced by the desire to obtain certain social goods including, but not limited to, those listed above.

References

- Alderson, P. (2001). Research by children. *International Journal of Social Research Methodology*, 4(2), 139–153. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13645570120003>
- American Educational Research Association. (2011). American Educational Research Association approved by the AERA council February 2011. *Educational Researcher*, 40(3), 145-156. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0013189X11410403>
- Bell, J. (2010). *Doing your research project: A guide for first-time researchers in education, health and social science* (5th ed.). McGraw-Hill.
- Bernard, M. P. (2013, December 13). The making of a Harvard feeder school. *The Harvard Crimson*. <https://www.thecrimson.com/article/2013/12/13/making-harvard-feeder-schools/>
- British Educational Research Association (BERA). (2018). *Ethical guidelines for educational research* (4th ed.). British Educational Research Association.
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). (2023). *LHS youth risk behavior survey data* [Data set]. <https://sites.google.com/lexingtonma.org/lexresearchreports/commonly-requested-reports-publications>
- Cu, M. A., & Hochman, S. (2023, January 22). Scores of Stanford students used ChatGPT on final exams, survey suggests. *The Stanford Daily*. <https://stanforddaily.com/2023/01/22/scores-of-stanford-students-used-chatgpt-on-final-exams-survey-suggests/>
- Dettori, J. R., Norvell, D. C. (2018). The anatomy of data. *Global Spine Journal*, 4(3), 311-313. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2192568217746998>
- Forman, N., Udvaros, J., & Avornicului, M. S. (2023). ChatGPT: A new study tool shaping the future for high school students. *International Journal of Advanced Natural Sciences and Engineering Researches*, 7(4), 95-102. <https://doi.org/10.59287/ijanser.562>
- Fosnot, C. T. (2005). Constructivism revisited: Implications and reflections. *The Constructivist*, 16(1), 1-17.
- Gee, J. P. (2014). *An introduction to discourse analysis: Theory and method* (4th ed.). Routledge.
- Guba, E. G., & Lincoln, Y. S. (1994). Competing paradigms in qualitative research. In N. K. Denzin & Y. S. Lincoln (Eds.), *Handbook of qualitative research* (pp. 105-117). Sage.
- Hasanein, A.M., & Sobaih, A. E. E. (2023). Drivers and consequences of ChatGPT use in higher education: Key stakeholder perspectives. *European Journal of Investigation in Health Psychology and Education*, 13(11), 2599-2614. <https://doi.org/10.3390%2Fjihpe13110181>
- Holland, D., Lachicotte Jr., W., Skinner, D., & Cain, C. (1998). *Identity and agency in cultural worlds*. Harvard University Press.
- Ingram, J., & Elliott, V. (2019). *Research methods for classroom discourse*. Bloomsbury.
- Javier, D. R. C., & Moorhouse, B. L. (2023). Developing secondary school English language learners' productive and critical use of ChatGPT. *TESOL Journal*, 15(2), 1-9. <https://doi.org/10.1002/tesj.755>
- Kershner, R., Hennessy, S., Wegerif, R., & Ahmed, A. (2020). *Research methods for educational dialogue*. Bloomsbury.
- Kvale, S. (1996). *Interviews: An introduction to qualitative research interviewing*. Sage.
- Lee, V. R., Pope, D., Miles, S., & Zárate, R. C. (2024). Cheating in the age of generative AI: A high school survey study of cheating behaviors before and after the release of ChatGPT. *Computers and Education: Artificial Intelligence*, 7. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.caeai.2024.100253>

- Levine, S., Beck, S. W., Mah, C., Phalen, L., & Pittman, J. (2024). How do students use ChatGPT as a writing support? *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 68(5) 445-457. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.1373>
- Lincoln, Y. S., & Guba, E. G. (1985). *Naturalistic inquiry*. Sage.
- Martinek, D., Zumbach, J., & Carmignola, M. (2022). How much pressure do students need to achieve good grades?—The relevance of autonomy support and school-related pressure for vitality, contentment with, and performance in school. *Education Sciences*, 12(8), 510. <https://doi.org/10.3390/educsci12080510>
- Mearian, L. (2023, April 25). Schools look to ban ChatGPT, students use it anyway. *Computer World*. <https://www.computerworld.com/article/3694195/schools-look-to-ban-chatgpt-students-use-it-anyway.html>
- Ng, D. T. K., Tan, C. W., & Leung, J. K. L. (2024). Empowering student self-regulated learning and science education through ChatGPT: A pioneering pilot study. *British Journal of Educational Technology*, 55(4), 1328-1353. <https://doi.org/10.1111/bjet.13454>
- Omona, J. (2013). Sampling in qualitative research: Improving the quality of research outcomes in higher education. *Makerere Journal of Higher Education*, 4(2). <https://doi.org/10.4314/majohe.v4i2.4>
- Ruslin, Mashuri, S., Rasak, M. S. A., Alhabsyi, F., & Syam, H. (2022). Semi-structured interview: A methodological reflection on the development of a qualitative research instrument in educational studies. *Journal of Research & Method in Education*, 2(1), 22-29. <https://doi.org/10.9790/7388-1201052229>
- Salmaan, A. F. (2023). Analysis of the effect of ChatGPT on the learning productivity of secondary school students. *International Conference on Education*, 1, 175-181. <https://jurnalfaktarbiyah.iainkediri.ac.id/index.php/proceedings/article/view/1819>
- Schelbe, L., Chanmugam, A., Moses, T., Saltzburg, S., Williams, L. R., & Letendre, J. (2014). Youth participation in qualitative research: Challenges and possibilities. *Qualitative Social Work*, 14(4), 504-521. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1473325014556792>
- Shin, Y. (2024). Students under academic pressure and their spillover effects on peers' mental well-being. *Labour Economics*, 90. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.labeco.2024.102564>
- Slocum, N., & Langenhove, L. V. (2004). The meaning of regional integration: Introducing positioning theory in regional integration studies. *Journal of European Integration*, 26(3), 227-252. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0703633042000261625>
- Spencer, K. (2017, April 5). It takes a suburb: A town struggles to ease student stress. *The New York Times*. <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/04/05/education/edlife/overachievers-student-stress-in-high-school-.html>
- Tamasese, K., & Denborough, D. (2024). Research as seeking help: Searching for liberative knowledge: An interview with Taimalieutu Kiwi Tamasese. *The Qualitative Report*, 29(12), 219-231. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2024.7871>
- UNESCO. (2023, June 1). *UNESCO survey: Less than 10% of schools and universities have formal guidance on AI*. <https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/unesco-survey-less-10-schools-and-universities-have-formal-guidance-ai>
- U. S. News and World Report. (2024). *Best Massachusetts high schools*. <https://www.usnews.com/education/best-high-schools/massachusetts/rankings>
- Ventayen, R. J. M. (2023). ChatGPT by OpenAI: Students' viewpoint on cheating using artificial intelligence-based application. *SSRN-Elsevir*. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4361548>
- Waltzer, T., Cox, R. L., & Heyman, G. D. (2023). Testing the ability of teachers and students to differentiate between essays generated by ChatGPT and high school students. *Human Behavior & Emerging Technologies*, 1-9. <https://doi.org/10.1155/2023/1923981>

- Wong, M. (2023, May 20). ChatGPT is already obsolete. *The Atlantic*. <https://www.theatlantic.com/technology/archive/2023/05/ai-advancements-multimodal-models/674113/>
- Zhang, K., & Aslan, A. (2021). AI technologies for education: Recent research & future directions. *Computers and Education: Artificial Intelligence*, 2. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.caeai.2021.100025>

Author Note

Saisha Gupta (Co-head researcher) is a high school student and co-head researcher for the Lexington Student Research and Publication Collaborative based in Massachusetts, USA. She works as a student researcher in the Yu Lab at Boston Children's Hospital, researching personalized genetic therapies in paediatric patients whose symptoms impact the central nervous system. Gupta is passionate about neuroscience, chemistry, and philosophy, and where these subjects intersect, she aims to study more in the future. She'll be attending New York University for Global Public Health and Chemistry in the Fall of 2025.

Vivek Mehta (Co-head researcher) is a high school senior passionate about changing the world through computation and a co-head researcher for the Lexington Student Research and Publication Collaborative based in Massachusetts, USA. Vivek co-captains their VEX Robotics team, a three-time competitor at the international level, and pursues research in computational biology. He is interested in blending his passions through teaching, problem-solving, and creative thinking. In the future, he hopes to use his skills and knowledge to develop solutions to positively impact the world around him. He enjoys playing the violin, baking, karate, and creating art in his free time. He'll be attending Carnegie Mellon University for Computer Science in the fall.

Rebecca Kam is a senior at Lexington High School in MA, USA. She is interested in language analysis and the effects of artificial intelligence on education, and she enjoys reading during her spare time.

Caroline Ehmann is a senior at Lexington High School in MA, USA. She co-captains Lexington's two-time national champion Envirothon team and her school's Science Olympiad team and is passionate about making tangible change through community outreach. She is interested in pursuing chemistry, math, and/or environmental studies after high school but also loves exploring new horizons in the social sciences. In her free time, she enjoys playing the cello and spending time outside hiking, jogging, and road-tripping to as many of the US National Parks as she can.

Alma Orgad is a senior at Lexington High School who is interested in the medical sciences, psychology, and literature. Outside of the LSRPC, Alma plays volleyball and plays guitar. Additionally, she has sung with the Boston Children's Choir. Currently, she is taking part in an emergency medicine summer programme with the Boston Leadership Institute. She would like to pursue a career in travel nursing due to her interests at the intersection of emergency medicine and her desire to help others globally.

Emily Kuang is a senior at Lexington High School in Massachusetts, USA, passionate about neuroscience and psychology with hopes to pursue academic research. She has worked as an intern at Professor Sander's lab at Boston University's Photonics Center and completed the Supervised Machine Learning: Regression and Classification course with Stanford Online, fueling her interest in AI's implementation and impact. Her hobbies include playing in an orchestra, drawing, and taking long walks.

Alejandro Castro Barrantes is a senior at Lexington High School. He is interested in materials science, psychology, and sports science. He won the Gold Presidential Volunteer Service Award in 2022, volunteering with youth sailing programs and as an English and math

tutor. In his free time, he runs his blacksmithing business, does martial arts, reads, and plays guitar.

Matthew Posada is a senior at Lexington High School. His interest lies in diversity in the biomedical sciences, attending various seminars and workshops from the Biomedical Science Careers Program.

Samay Shah is a senior at Lexington High School passionate about various community service projects including co-leading a middle school debate program, instituting a memory training program at a local senior living home, and founding a nonprofit organisation dedicated to providing career education to underprivileged students. On the side, he writes for his school newspaper and resells sneakers.

Tara Pai is a senior at Lexington High School. She is passionate about AI, educational advocacy, and student and teacher perspectives of ChatGPT. She previously attended Boston University's AI4ALL program and currently serves as chair of a digital literacy workgroup with the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education.

Nikhita Prasad is a senior at Lexington High School. She has enjoyed learning more about AI in education, and in her free time, she enjoys playing tennis, listening to music, and spending time with friends and family.

Eileen Ho is a senior at Lexington High School. She is passionate about the intersections between technology and policy and is involved in local policies and legislation concerning environmental issues. She hopes to extend the breadth of her advocacy to the impacts of AI. In her free time, she enjoys playing the violin and reading books.

Tianyi Zhou is a senior at Lexington High School interested in applications of educational psychology and computer science. Outside of this project, she runs an educational non-profit called Numberosity, which teaches maths and computer science to middle schoolers from underserved populations. Tianyi also enjoys creative writing.

Elaina Li is a senior at Lexington High School who is fascinated by the fine arts, dance, and literature. She won the *New York Times* "Coming of Age" competition in 2022. She is a member of a variety of organisations.

Stephanie Wan is a senior attending Lexington High School in MA, USA who is interested in learning, cognition, consciousness, and their intersections with modern technology. She has done research in bioinformatics, metascience, and machine learning applications on linguistics as part of MIT PRIMES. In her free time, she can be found reading, playing around with cybersecurity and information theory, and drawing.

Shirley Xi is a senior attending Lexington High School. Her interest lies in the biomedical sciences and ethics surrounding AI usage. She has enjoyed thoroughly researching the impacts of AI on education. In her free time, she runs a nonprofit for expanding the outreach of volleyball to underprivileged communities.

Shreya Paranjape is a senior at Lexington High School and a proud member of the Lexington Wind Ensemble, where she plays the flute. When not immersed in music, she enjoys baking, reading, and spending time with friends. With a passion for science and discovery, she aspires to pursue a career in biomedical research, aiming to make meaningful contributions to healthcare and innovation.

Zoe Dearling is a junior attending Lexington High School. She is interested in biology, especially cellular and marine biology. Outside of school, Zoe is an elite swimmer on both a high-performance club team and her high school team. Outside of her studies and swimming, she enjoys reading, writing, and completing the New York Times puzzles.

Siqi (Grace) Peng is a junior attending Lexington High School. She is interested in pursuing a career in pre-med, especially in research on neurodegenerative diseases and global health issues. She is also Co-President of the Young Women in Medicine chapter at LHS and

is passionate about advocating for women in the STEM fields. Outside of school, Grace can be found at the ice rink with her synchronized skating team, or in the kitchen whipping up baked goods.

Aanya Kaveti is a sophomore at Lexington High School with a passion for debate and educational advocacy. She is a Varsity policy debater and enjoys mentoring younger students in debate. Aanya has an interest in pursuing law with a focus on intellectual property in healthcare. Outside of academics, she holds a black belt in karate and is a defensive specialist on her school's JV volleyball team.

Gwendolyn Lowrance, a sophomore at Lexington High School, is interested in cognitive development and AI's effect on student learning. She is a peer mentor through the Best Buddies chapter at LHS and is passionate about building supportive environments for students with intellectual disabilities. Gwendolyn is also the Varsity goalie for the school's field hockey team and enjoys music, reading, and skiing.

Angela Ziyi Xie is a sophomore attending Lexington High School with a passion for exploring the intersections of cultural relations and identity. As a policy debater, she combines her love for writing and argumentation to delve into societal issues. Outside the competitive world of debate, you can find her playing volleyball with friends or writing her literary review column in LHS's newspaper, *The Musket*.

Mira Xu is a sophomore at Lexington High school. She is passionate about neuroscience and physics, subjects that have paved the way into her interest in AI. She is part of her school's math and science bowl team. In her free time, she enjoys writing, reading, and walking her dog.

Adhiti Hariram is a sophomore at Lexington High school. She is interested in biology, especially anatomy and biotechnology, and is passionate about neuroscience and music. Adhiti is also in honors chorus and on the varsity tennis team. Outside of school Adhiti is a competitive tennis player and Indian classical singer. In her free time, she enjoys reading, music, and hiking.

Alexa Muse (Supervisor and Teacher) is both a Ph.D. Education candidate at the University of Oxford (UK) and a high school English teacher at Lexington High School (MA, USA). With eleven years of middle, secondary, and university teaching experience both in the United States and abroad (Turkey, Russia, and the UK), Alexa is interested in the intersection of democratic education pedagogies, policy, and teacher contexts. Other interests of hers include Cultural Historical Activity Theory, Figured Worlds, and narratology. Her undergraduate degree (BS Middle/Secondary English Education) is from Butler University in Indianapolis, Indiana (USA). Her Master's degree (MSc Learning and Teaching) is from the University of Oxford. ORCID iD: 0009-0007-2957-9625 Please direct correspondence to alexa.muse@education.ox.ac.uk

Author Contribution: All students worked on the writing, researching, editing, and analyzing aspects of this paper.

Acknowledgements: From Lexington Public Schools (Massachusetts), we want to thank Ms. Jane Day, English Department Chair, Mr. Scott Kmack, dean, Mr. Andrew Baker, principal, and especially Dr. Julie Hackett, superintendent. Each of them went above and beyond to support this project, writing letters of approval, and providing opportunities to present our research. Additionally, we would like to acknowledge Dr. Velda Elliott from the University of Oxford for providing guidance, advice, and the opportunity to present at the university. We would like to thank Dr. Sally St. George and Dr. Dan Wulff for working with us so patiently, walking us through this process chunk by chunk. Finally, we want to acknowledge our peers who began this project in Spring 2023 in Literature and Composition II: Nour Aboshady, Sophia Alcacaer, Laya Barghuthi, Calliope Bruce, Geneva Carter, Philip

Chung, Anna Fullerton, Micaela Gebrael, Taili Gao, Kabir Gokarn, Vaidehi Gupta, Calix Huang, Sofia Kalofonos, Ellie Kim, Alkisti Kokkinia, Lucy Kontos, Anna Labbe, Arthur Lin, Charlotte Longley, Abigail Man, Susannah McElheny, Kaavya Moogala, Juliana Nudi, Tyler Portillo, Bella Qu, Sofia Rosica, Mirei Saneyoshi, Sophie Shaw, Sophie Schenk, Catherine Taibi, Sophia Tang, Athina-Anna Vlachos, Angela Yates, Guhan Yuvaraj, and Emily Zhou.

Copyright 2025: Saisha Gupta, Vivek Mehta, Rebecca Kam, Caroline Ehmann, Alma Orgad, Emily Kuang, Alejandro Castro Barrantes, Matthew Posada, Samay Shah, Nikhita Prasad, Tara Pai, Eileen Ho, Shirley Xi, Tianyi Zhou, Elaina Li, Stephanie Wan, Shreya Paranjape, Zoe Dearling, Siqi (Grace) Peng, Aanya Kaveti, Gwendolyn Lowrance, Angela Ziyi Xie, Mira Xu, Adhiti Hariram, Alexa Muse, and Nova Southeastern University.

Article Citation

Gupta, S., Mehta, V., Kam, R., Ehmann, C., Orgad, A., Kuang, E., Castro Barrantes, A., Posada, M., Shah, S., Prasad, N., Pai, T., Ho, E., Xi, S., Zhou, T., Li, E., Wan, S., Paranjape, S., Dearling, Z., Peng, S. (G.), Kaveti, A., Lowrance, G., Xie, A. Z., Xu, M., Hariram, A., & Muse, A. (2025). A teacher, a tutor, a friend: ChatGPT and the high school experience. *The Qualitative Report*, 30(5), 3686-3719. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2025.7324>
